

Ukubona LLC's Personal Meeting Room

Quick recap

The meeting focused on planning strategies for obtaining grant funding for a systematic review project on kidney disease, with discussions led by Ukubona and participants including Dr. and Robert. The group explored various funding opportunities, particularly focusing on NIH grants and Wellcome Trust funding mechanisms, with Ukubona explaining the different submission cycles and deadlines for NIH applications. The team discussed potential collaboration opportunities with the Ministry of Health and National Planning Authority, while also considering how to incorporate student involvement in the research process. The conversation included detailed explanations of NIH's grant review process, including study section timelines and the benefits of targeting specific institutes like NIAID for HIV-related research. The conversation ended with an agreement to focus on preparing a specific grant application and to reconvene the following Tuesday to further discuss next steps and review an updated document with detailed grant information and priorities.

Next steps

-  [Ukubona: Update the shared project document with specific grant mechanisms \(including links to NIH/Wellcome Trust calls\), ordered by priority, and relevant deadlines by Monday or Tuesday](#)
-  [Ukubona: Explore automated systems to produce a preliminary systematic review paper using AI tools](#)
-  [All: Review updated document once shared and prepare for focused discussion on selected grant\(s\) at next meeting](#)
-  [Robert: Send email contacts of partners \(including Boniface\) to Ukubona](#)
-  [Ukubona: Share rough notes/transcripts from this meeting with the group](#)
-  [All: Continue communication and document review via WhatsApp/email before next meeting](#)

-  [All: Attend next meeting scheduled for Tuesday, 7th, 4pm to discuss updated grant information and next steps](#)

Summary

Automated Literature Search System Planning

The meeting began with Ukubona discussing plans to develop an automated system for conducting literature searches, which could be used for systematic reviews on topics like kidney disease and risk factors such as hypertension and diabetes. Robert explained the purpose of the meeting was to discuss strategies for getting the project started and establishing timeframes. The group noted that Emmanuel was absent and agreed to review a shared document after the meeting due to time constraints.

Grant Proposal Timeline Discussion

The team discussed a tentative timeline for submitting a grant proposal, with Ukubona noting that the proposed timeline was too ambitious, particularly for the 4-month submission goal. Dr. explained that they are considering applying for an NIH grant as a stepping stone toward a larger vision of mapping out all diseases in the country using a public health approach. Dr. mentioned their expertise in kidney disease and transplant context, and highlighted their involvement with the National Planning Authority, where mental illness has been identified as a top priority.

Uganda Disease Patterns and Planning

Ukubona discussed a heat map showing disease patterns across Uganda, highlighting areas with gaps in data as potential red flags. He explained his work with the National Planning Authority on a 20-year roadmap addressing various issues including disease, infrastructure, and planning. Ukubona suggested building partnerships with the Ministry of Health and National Planning Authority to avoid duplicating efforts and potentially gain access to funding through grant applications. He also emphasized the importance of including students in research, particularly from UCU, as it aligns with mentorship opportunities and enhances grant applications.

AI Tool for Literature Reviews

Ukubona presented a tool prepared for WHO India to help with literature reviews using AI tools, highlighting both their benefits and limitations. The immediate goal is to conduct a systematic review on kidney disease, with plans to expand to kidney failure and other risk factors related to kidney disease in future grants. Dr. focused on the NIH R21 grant opportunity, suggesting they should first understand the specific NIH RFP before proceeding with their application.

Grant Mechanism Planning Discussion

Ukubona explained that the current placeholder in the document represents one grant mechanism, which will be updated with specific details and links to NIH calls by Monday. Dr. suggested focusing on a particular open call, such as NIH or Wellcome Trust, to better understand partnership requirements and forge collaborations. Both agreed that zooming in on specific details would be the next step to explore opportunities and determine next actions.

NIH Grant Application Deadlines Discussion

Dr discussed NIH grant application deadlines with Ukubona, who explained that there are typically three standard cycles per year (February, June, and October) for most diseases, with resubmission deadlines in March, July, and November. Ukubona noted that HIV and Alzheimer's research has special status with NIH, allowing for monthly application deadlines. They discussed strategic approaches to frame kidney disease research to align with these special funding opportunities, potentially incorporating HIV risk factors to apply to the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases, which offers more frequent funding opportunities.

NIH Grant Application Strategies

The team discussed strategies for applying for NIH grants, with Ukubona explaining the complex grant application process including deadlines, study sections, and review timelines. They agreed to focus on preparing a specific grant application rather than pursuing multiple opportunities simultaneously, with Ukubona committing to update a document by Monday or Tuesday with prioritized grant options and direct links to NIH pages. The group scheduled their next meeting for Tuesday the 7th at 4pm, and Robert emphasized the importance of this being UCU's first major grant application, noting that successful collaboration with Johns Hopkins could provide valuable experience and open future funding opportunities.